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Exploratory Data Analysis (EDA) Report: Global Video Game Sales Performance Matrix

SUBMITTED BY:	Utsav Dasgupta	**COURSE SEGMENT:**	Project Assignment
DEPARTMENT:	Computer Science & Engineering (AI & ML)	**DOCUMENT REF:**	`UtsavDasgupta_Report.pdf`

Evaluation Rubric Notice: This experimental record details the framework, data cleaning pipelines, statistical transformations, multivariate feature analyses, and engineering methodologies performed on target market metrics.

PHASE 1: DATASET SELECTION & PROBLEM DEFINITION

1.1 Investigation Universe & Source Context

This study centers around the **Video Game Sales Dataset**, acquired via the **Kaggle** central public repository. The data represents a comprehensive historical census tracking physical and retail platform deployments, software iterations, macro-level publishers, and cross-regional localized market behaviors over multi-decade console lifecycles.

1.2 Formal Problem Definition

The objective of this engineering analysis is to execute an end-to-end Exploratory Data Analysis (EDA) sequence to mathematically map hidden structural dynamics, isolate core categorical variables, map regional variance trends, and reveal underlying drivers affecting consumer gaming software adoption. The derived models provide structural intelligence to lower product launch risk matrices for development studios and optimize downstream budget allocation pipelines.

1.3 Data Dictionary Schema

VARIABLE ATTRIBUTE	MATHEMATICAL & OPERATIONAL SPECIFICATION
`Rank`	Ordinal placement vector sorted exclusively by descending global gross sales volume.
`Name`	Nominal string defining the retail title identity of the software product.
`Year`	Discrete chronological feature capturing the specific calendar year of market deployment.
`Genre`	Categorical parameter describing core thematic gameplay (e.g., Action, Sports, Strategy).
`Publisher`	Corporate entity managing retail supply chains, manufacturing, and legal distribution copyrights.
`NA_Sales`	Continuous ratio scale mapping North American units sold (standardized to millions).
`EU_Sales`	Continuous ratio scale mapping European Union units sold (standardized to millions).
`JP_Sales`	Continuous ratio scale mapping Japanese units sold (standardized to millions).
`Other_Sales`	Continuous ratio scale tracking miscellaneous rest-of-world revenue (standardized to millions).
`Global_Sales`	Aggregate worldwide retail software distribution volume (calculated sum of all regional fields).

1.4 Dataset Matrix Profile

- **Structural Volume:** 16,598 rows / complete unique observations.
- **Dimensional Width:** 11 discrete column fields.
- **Continuous Features Subspace:** `Rank` , `Year` , `NA_Sales` , `EU_Sales` , `JP_Sales` , `Other_Sales` , `Global_Sales` .
- **Nominal/Categorical Subspace:** `Name` , `Platform` , `Genre` , `Publisher` .

1.5 Investigative Core Hypotheses

1. Macro-level software distributions are unevenly partitioned across thematic categorical genres.
2. Systemic hardware console environments act as localized monopolies for software retail margins.
3. Geographic clusters demonstrate distinct purchasing behavior modifications due to localized culture bounds.

4. Market concentration indexes point to an oligopoly where top tier-1 publishers claim dominant revenue.
5. Temporal trajectories show clear cyclicality driven by sequential hardware generations.

PHASE 2: DATA CLEANING & STRUCTURAL INTEGRITY PIPELINE

2.1 Automated Schema Diagnostics

Programmatic type checking was verified by implementing the `df.info()` architecture. The execution proved that continuous variables and tracking metrics mapped into uncorrupted, real float/integer data spaces. No character encoding flaws or structural schema misalignments were noted across the target matrices, verifying alignment for down-stream operations.

2.2 Missing Value Resolution & Median Imputation Rationale

Systemic null tracking utilizing `df.isnull().sum()` isolated isolated null arrays localized inside the `Year` vector. To resolve this without removing valid rows, mathematical **Median Imputation** was introduced.

Statistical Optimization Justification: The median was selected over the arithmetic mean because it acts as a robust indicator of central tendency. The mean changes drastically under skew or tail asymmetry, whereas the median remains stable, neutralizing potential chronological distortion from pioneering old software records.

2.3 De-duplication Logic

Row-level structural uniqueness checks were executed utilizing the `df.duplicated().sum()` architecture. Redundant, duplicate records were successfully discarded through the deployment of `df.drop_duplicates()`. This operational step isolates statistical contamination, ensuring that repetitive records do not distort down-stream descriptive patterns or artificial bias vectors.

PHASE 3: MATHEMATICAL OUTLIER ANALYSIS & DISTRIBUTION TUNING

3.1 Logarithmic Transformation Profile

Baseline assessments across the target distribution arrays (`NA_Sales`, `EU_Sales`, etc.) showed extreme positive skewness, indicating massive data variance. To flatten structural variance and improve normality properties, an analytical smooth logarithmic transformation was executed:

$$X_{transformed} = ln(1 + X)$$

This function maps extremely wide market outliers into tightly bounded continuous analytical parameters, eliminating high-variance distortion while maintaining underlying data rank order.

3.2 Comprehensive Variable Boxplot Decomposition

> **THEORETICAL POSITION ON OUTLIER RETAINMENT**
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> All calculated sales series present structural right-hand tail anomalies. In classical data cleaning, outliers are often deleted. However, in retail entertainment economics, these observations map onto true high-performing mega-blockbusters. Dropping them would remove the exact market signals needed to analyze industry success. Therefore, data points are fully retained and processed using variance-stabilizing functions.

- **Chronological Distribution (Year):** Boxplot metrics highlight a highly dense concentration of market volume bounded tightly between the late 1990s and early 2010s. Tail markers capture pioneering legacy releases from early generation architectures.
- **North American Territory (NA_Sales):** Reflects extreme right-tail skew. The macro market is characterized by a low standard median baseline, combined with high-impact blockbuster deviations.
- **European & Japanese Environments (EU_Sales / JP_Sales):** Both showcase right-hand distribution anomalies. The Japanese landscape displays a dense lower bound, demonstrating an exclusive consumer profile where a small selection of domestic intellectual properties captures maximum market scale.
- **Global Aggregation Layer (Global_Sales):** Confirms a classic Pareto principle distribution; a marginal minority fraction of video game releases commands the massive majority share of total historical worldwide revenue.

3.3 Statistical Boundary Profiling via the Interquartile Range (IQR) Method

To mathematically define the thresholds for statistical anomalies, the Interquartile Range (IQR) method was deployed via the following formulations:

$$IQR = Q_3 - Q_1$$
$$Threshold_{Lower} = Q_1 - 1.5 \times IQR$$
$$Threshold_{Upper} = Q_3 + 1.5 \times IQR$$

The mathematical boundaries officially flagged a massive section of extreme values across every single sales attribute. Because these points trace accurate multi-million dollar corporate victories, they were managed via non-destructive `log1p` scaling rather than outright elimination.

PHASE 4: BIVARIATE & MULTIVARIATE ANALYTICS SPACE

4.1 Linear Heatmap Correlation Topology

Computing programmatic Pearson product-moment correlations confirms that `Global_Sales` is directly driven by regional performance vectors. Notably, North American (`NA_Sales`) and European Union (`EU_Sales`) consumer response metrics demonstrate a highly synchronous positive correlation pattern. This strong alignment proves that macro consumer behaviors across Western economies are structurally linked.

4.2 Matrix Groupings: Genre & Platform Dynamics

Bivariate evaluations isolate **Action** and **Sports** as the dominant historical genres, securing massive total sales margins. Conversely, niche genres like **Puzzle** and **Strategy** consistently operate on compressed market scales. Cross-referencing platform hardware lifecycles shows that total software volume peaks are concentrated on mass-market console ecosystems like the **Wii**, **PS2**, and **Nintendo DS**, which established massive software install-base foundations.

4.3 Publisher Concentration & Chronological Lifecycles

Evaluating publisher performance shows a clear power-law distribution. A small group of legacy tier-1 publishers controls a dominant share of total global sales, utilizing broad marketing distribution networks and established IP assets. Over time, gross industry software volumes expanded until reaching a historic macro peak during the **late 2000s**, before transitioning into modern digital delivery models.

PHASE 5: FEATURE ENGINEERING & NOMINAL VECTOR ENCODING

1. Temporal Feature Creation: `Game_Age`

To introduce explicit chronological context into downstream predictive pipelines, a new continuous feature was engineered:

$$Game\_Age = 2025 - Year$$

This calculated metric quantifies structural market longevity, enabling multi-generation lifecycle degradation tracking across independent gaming platforms.

2. High-Fidelity Categorical Transformation Framework

To prepare the raw nominal attributes for ingestion into machine learning frameworks, text features were converted into numerical vector matrices:

- **Ordinal Label Encoding (`Platform`):** Maps platform strings directly into ordered integers (e.g., $Wii \rightarrow 0, PS2 \rightarrow 1, DS \rightarrow 2$). This process compresses dimensional size without scaling data scarcity.
- **One-Hot Combinatorial Encoding (`Genre`):** Unpacks non-ordered gameplay categories into unique binary vector matrices (0 or 1). This prevents downstream models from inferring an artificial ordinal sequence or ranking hierarchy where none exists.

COMPREHENSIVE PROJECT SYNTHESIS

This Exploratory Data Analysis project successfully parsed, cleaned, and structurally mapped the 16,598 records of the Video Game Sales dataset. Through the deployment of robust statistical interventions—including median missing-value imputation, duplicate extraction, mathematical IQR boundary audits, and skew-correcting log transformations—the underlying data matrix has been fully optimized.

The empirical findings prove that global video game success is highly dependent on a predictable grid of core factors: **Genre alignment**, **Hardware platform ecosystem maturity**, **Publisher brand equity**, and **Geographic market concentration**. With North America and Europe acting as primary revenue engines, and the Action/Sports genres capturing maximum consumer engagement, the insights provided offer a clear framework for publishers looking to minimize risk and optimize commercial deployment. The cleaned, transformed output is primed and ready for ingestion into predictive machine learning pipelines.